When Khrushchev presented his ideas to the Presidium and the Defence Council in May 1962, he said the purpose was to deter a US attack on Cuba. Yet, among Western historians, a consensus developed that emphasised Soviet strategic nuclear inferiority as the reason for the decision. In 1987 Raymond Garthoff observed, 'there is a general consensus that the principal motivation was to redress the publicly revealed serious imbalance in the strategic nuclear balance. No other action satisfactorily accounts for the action.'[50] Some see Roswell Gilpatric's speech of October 1961 as decisive in prompting Khrushchev's decision.

Other factors nevertheless excited the interest of historians. In 1987 Blight and Welch identified no less than eight hypotheses used to explain Khrushchev's motivation: the defence of Cuba; 'missile gap repair'; a bargaining chip to remove NATO missiles, especially from Turkey; Berlin; rivalry with China; Cold War politics; distraction from domestic failures (especially in agriculture); pressure from hardliners in the Kremlin.[51]

Testimony from Soviet officials in the late 1980s and 1990s, including at various 'critical oral conferences,' placed greater weight on the defence of Cuba. This was reinforced by revelations about Operation Mongoose, and the covert attempts by Washington to overthrow Castro's government. At a conference in Moscow in 1989 Robert McNamara suggested that US covert action had played an important part in generating the misperception that Washington was preparing an invasion[52]

Nevertheless, there were differences in perspective among Soviet officials. Lebow and Stein summarise the views of former senior officials and commentators: Sergei Khrushchev, Georgiy Kornienko, Aleksandr Alekseev, and Sergo Mikoyan believed the main purpose was to protect Cuba; Georgiy Shakhnazarov and Dmitri Volkogonov (as well as Fidel Castro) believed the primary concern was the strategic balance; while Aleksei Adzhubei and Leonid Zamyatin thought it was 'psychological equality' to compel fundamental changes in US foreign policy.[53]

Archival disclosures in the 1990s provided grist for various mills. Fursenko and Naftali presented a nuanced analysis of Soviet policymaking. They invoked Agatha Christie's *Murder on the Orient Express* (where Hercule Poirot concludes the evil Mr Ratchett was murdered by all twelve